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Topic 1: Addressing Enforced Disappearances by Government Regimes

The delegation of the United Kingdom is deeply concerned about enforced disappearances by government regimes, which are defined as abduction or unlawful detention by the state, political organization, or a third party with the authority of a state or organization. Since 1980, the UN Working Group on Enforced or Involuntary Disappearances has reported more than 59,000 cases of disappearances in 110 countries¹, with most being witnesses, lawyers, human rights defenders, or relatives of those previously abducted.² These cases are filed without stating their whereabouts, often spreading fear, suppressing opposition, and maintaining control,³ and since there are no warrants for arrest in enforced disappearances, nor a fair trial for most victims, it is difficult to enforce laws or assess these situations as there is little data. Enforced disappearances are also a crime against humanity when it is systematic and widespread because it violates several human rights, including the right to security and dignity of a person and the right to a fair trial⁴. It may also be a threat to democracy when one group oppresses the other's views by abducting their opponents. Thus, it is crucial to introduce solutions that assist victims and their families, as well as to prevent cases from happening and improve legislature in individual countries urgently without infringing upon national sovereignty to ensure peace, security, human rights, and democracy. The UK believes that through the use of NGOs such as Amnesty International, we can help provide necessities and legal support to families of victims, advocate for the removal of national laws that hinder support systems for the victims' families, and protect those who are in danger of being abducted. These measures will help implement effective care for those affected and reduce disappearances.

Both the United Kingdom and the UN have made efforts to address enforced disappearances. The UK has made its view condemning enforced disappearances clear and urges states to investigate allegations. To combat it, the UK works through multilateral systems and makes use of its diplomatic network to promote awareness of individual cases and to enhance cooperation by expressing its alarm for acts of intimidation or reprisal against defenders who cooperate with the UN on behalf of 74 nations. The UK has also focused on internet use and how

¹"Enforced or involuntary disappearances Report of the Working Group on Enforced or Involuntary Disappearances." *United Nations General Assembly*, UN, 4 August 2021, <https://documents-dds-ny.un.org/doc/UNDOC/GEN/G21/215/21/PDF/G2121521.pdf?OpenElement>. Accessed 22 October 2023.

² Amnesty International. "Enforced Disappearances." *Amnesty International*, Amnesty International, <https://www.amnesty.org/en/what-we-do/enforced-disappearances/>. Accessed 22 October 2023.

³ *About Enforced Disappearance* | Ohchr, www.ohchr.org/en/special-procedures/wg-disappearances/about-enforced-disappearance. Accessed 23 Oct. 2023.

⁴"International Day of the Victims of Enforced Disappearances." *United Nations*, United Nations, www.un.org/en/observances/victims-enforced-disappearance. Accessed 22 Oct. 2023.

it enables freedom when used as a forum, especially for women.⁵ The UN has also created numerous committees and conventions against enforced disappearances, such as the Working Group and Committee on Enforced or Involuntary Disappearances (WGEID). These committees assist families and provide a channel of communication⁶. Even more impactfully, these committees create an obligation for states to criminalize it and affirm enforced disappearances as a crime against humanity. These also create an obligation for states to accept the verdict of outside organizations such as the ICC⁷. The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (ICCPR), which the UK is a signatory of, also condemns enforced disappearances. Although critics point out that the more serious offending countries in all regions of the world such as China, Cuba, and North Korea have not yet ratified these treaties or tried to withdraw, the UK still hopes for them to join in the future. The UK expresses its appreciation for the aforementioned efforts of the UN and other countries in communication with the UK.

The UK believes that providing necessities and legislative support to families of victims, advocating for the removal of laws that prevent the victims' families from getting access to support systems, and protecting those in danger will be the first step in preventing enforced disappearances. In many cases, the disappeared person is the breadwinner for their family and provides a source of income, and as they disappear, it leaves their families vulnerable. This leads to economic strain as well. Thus, providing necessities such as shelter, food, and water is crucial for the well-being of families, and legislative support is needed to be able to receive compensation and acknowledgment from the acting parties for their actions. Furthermore, many countries have laws that make it impossible for families to receive support through social systems such as pensions without a death certificate. By removing such legislation, it will improve the victims' situations. Lastly, the UK believes that prevention is the most important action that needs to be taken. By protecting those who are commonly targeted such as human rights workers, witnesses, and certain lawyers, numerous tragedies can be avoided. With partnerships with NGOs such as Amnesty International and local NGOs that specialize in certain regions, this will be possible, as the UK and UN can provide funding in exchange of networks within certain countries and specialized knowledge. The delegation of the UK believes that enforced disappearances affect thousands and many more indirectly, and it is crucial that through financial and legislative means, this issue is resolved.

⁵ "Cases of Enforced Disappearance Climb to Nearly 1,000 Daily, United Nations Expert Warns Third Committee, as Delegates Call for Upholding Key Human Rights Treaties | UN Press." *United Nations*, United Nations, press.un.org/en/2020/gashc4297.doc.htm. Accessed 31 Oct. 2023.

⁶ *Working Group on Enforced or Involuntary Disappearances* | *Ohchr*, www.ohchr.org/en/special-procedures/wg-disappearances. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

⁷ *International Convention for the Protection of All Persons From ...*, www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-convention-protection-all-persons-enforced. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

Topic 2: Confronting the Exploitation of Mineral Resources in Afghanistan

The delegation of the U.K. is alarmed by the exploitation of mineral resources in Afghanistan, which is estimated to be worth about \$1 Trillion. These minerals such as copper, steel, marble, coal, lithium, cobalt, gold, and various precious gems⁸ are desperately needed in many industries, especially electric cars, and could contribute to Afghanistan's sustainable growth.⁹ However, Afghanistan faces challenges such as inadequate infrastructure, technology, and corruption¹⁰ which hinder the growth of the mining sector. Afghanistan also has an aid-dependent economy, with 90% of the population below the poverty line, and human rights problems such as the use of child labor and the exploitation of locals to work in dangerous conditions are prevalent. Further concerning is the frequent use of strip mining, an ecologically devastating technique, to mine quickly and export it to avoid getting caught up in sanctions,¹¹ In all of this, however, there is a risk that the revenue generated from mining is used to fund terrorist activities to expand the Taliban's control.¹² The UK recognizes the difference between Afghanistan and the Taliban, however, and wishes to assist Afghanistan without aiding terrorist activities or internal conflict involving violence in the Taliban. Foreign exploitation of resources, particularly by China and Pakistan as part of the Belt and Road initiative, should also be addressed, given trade with the Taliban could lead to unexpected consequences such as foreign exploitation of Afghanistan. To resolve these challenges and make mining sustainable, the UK would like to continue to provide humanitarian aid to the people of Afghanistan with an emphasis on improving the dire conditions of the mines and ending child labor, and if the Taliban is willing to communicate with the United Nations and the UK, aid in fabricating a legal/administrative framework for the mining sector, constructing a safer and more environmentally conscious way of mining, assistance in preventing exploitation of resources by foreign powers, and negotiating sanctions again with other countries such as the US.

The UK and United Nations have made efforts to confront the exploitation of mineral resources in Afghanistan. First, the UK has provided more than £3.85 million in technical assistance to the Ministry of Mines and the Afghan Geological Survey to build the capacity of institutions to manage resources and attract foreign investment through the Department for International Development (DfID). It has also provided £1 million to the Afghanistan Investment Guarantee Fund (AIGF), which is a World Bank-administered trust fund that seeks to help entrepreneurs overcome risks associated with Afghanistan's fragile state that is still healing after conflict. It also provides funding for research creating jobs and wealth, such as the Afghanistan Research and Evaluation Unit (AREU) which explores prospects for trade in various sectors.

⁸ Horowitz, Julia. "The Taliban Are Sitting on \$1 Trillion Worth of Minerals the World Desperately Needs | CNN Business." *CNN*, Cable News Network, 19 Aug. 2021, www.cnn.com/2021/08/18/business/afghanistan-lithium-rare-earths-mining/index.html.

⁹ [https://twitter.com/WorldBank, <http://www.youtube.com/WorldBank>, and Person. "Mining for Sustainable Growth in Afghanistan." *World Bank*, World Bank Group, 21 Sept. 2021, www.worldbank.org/en/news/feature/2010/09/01/mining-for-sustainable-growth-in-afghanistan.

¹⁰ Azzam, Abdullah. "Developing Afghanistan's Mines Will Uplift Afghans." *Opinions | Al Jazeera*, Al Jazeera, 23 Sept. 2023, www.aljazeera.com/opinions/2023/9/23/developing-afghanistans-mines-will-uplift-afghans.

¹¹ h2#authors-1.section-title:after{background:#fff !important;}@media (min-width: 600px) { h2#authors-1.section-title{margin-top: -50px;margin-bottom: 100px;} h2#authors-1.section-title:after{margin-top: -50px;margin-bottom: -50px;} }@media (max-wi, and Jason Bartlett
Research Associate. "Sanctions by the Numbers: Spotlight on Afghanistan." *Center for a New American Security (En-US)*, www.cnas.org/publications/reports/sanctions-by-the-numbers-afghanistan. Accessed 25 Oct. 2023. Former

¹² Hummel, Kristina. "The Taliban Stones Commission and the Insurgent Windfall from Illegal Mining." *Combating Terrorism Center at West Point*, 16 Nov. 2017, etc.westpoint.edu/the-taliban-stones-commission-and-the-insurgent-windfall-from-illegal-mining/.

Lastly, DfID has provided £3 million for research for agricultural livelihood options for rural Afghans by identifying market opportunities and high-value crops and provides £3.7 million for farmers in Eastern Hazarajat, which is one of the most underdeveloped areas in Afghanistan, to identify innovative ways for them to make a living. The UK will continue such aid, which totals about £3.5 Billion overall.¹³ The UK believes that the resources in Afghanistan should be used in a humanitarian and environmentally-conscious way. Therefore, it has also expressed support to the Minister of Mines along with over 100 more representatives by announcing a £10 million DfID program over 3 years to support the Ministry of Mines in monitoring contracts and appointing experts.¹⁴ Second, the United Nations has also made considerable efforts against the exploitation of resources in Afghanistan with an emphasis on warning countries about civil conflict over mineral deposits and protecting children from hazardous child labor.¹⁵ The UK appreciates the efforts by the UN against mineral exploitation of Afghanistan and cooperation with Afghanistan.

Having considered the situation in Afghanistan, the UK believes that continued humanitarian aid to Afghanistan to end child labor and improve the conditions in mines continued negotiations with the Taliban to guarantee human rights to Afghans and if they are willing to communicate, assistance in fabricating a legal/administrative framework and develop a safer and environmentally conscious mining technology, as well as assistance in preventing exploitation by foreign powers, and negotiating sanctions once more with the US and the UN, the exploitation of resources in Afghanistan can end. First, the UK stresses the difference between the Taliban government and Afghanistan citizens once more and wishes to further annual humanitarian aid to Afghanistan. However, considering the urgency of the issue, the UK will be focusing on ending child labor and improving conditions in mines that arise with the exploitation of minerals. Second, if the Taliban government continues negotiations with the United Nations to improve human rights vastly, the UK will assist in contriving a legal/administrative framework and in developing mining technology that is safer and more environmentally conscious. The UK would also assist in protecting its resources from foreign powers and renegotiating sanctions with the UN and the United States. The delegation of the UK believes balance is key in resolving the crisis of mineral exploitation in Afghanistan and this can be achieved through humanitarian aid and legislative assistance.

¹³ *Hansard - UK Parliament*, hansard.parliament.uk/. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

¹⁴ Development, Department for International. "UK Support to Harness Natural Resource Wealth in Afghanistan." *GOV.UK*, GOV.UK, 7 Mar. 2013, www.gov.uk/government/news/uk-support-to-harness-natural-resource-wealth-in-afghanistan.

¹⁵ "Child Protection." *UNICEF Afghanistan*, www.unicef.org/afghanistan/child-protection. Accessed 31 Oct. 2023.

Topic 3: Combating the Rise of Synthetic Drugs

The delegation of the U.K. solemnly affirms combating the rise of synthetic drugs which are often made to replicate the effects of preexisting plant-based drugs through artificial means.¹⁶ With the growth of technology and science, especially in the fields of Medicinal Chemistry and sometimes even through the use of Artificial Intelligence¹⁷, synthetic drugs have flourished and drug dealers are beginning to mass produce these highly lucrative and cheaper drugs,¹⁸ sometimes even substituting originals with their cheaper and stronger counterparts without notifying the user, which leads to higher rates of overdose. Moreover, it is difficult to regulate the raw chemicals since they are used in many legal ways. There are more than hundreds of synthetic drugs, including fentanyl, methamphetamines, MDMA, and nitazenes, and more unknown substances.¹⁹ Of particular concern is the substitution of existing drugs with much stronger and cheaper synthetic drugs, leading to a higher risk of fatal overdoses. Prolonged use results in severe and long-lasting side effects, affecting the user's brain, mood, impulse control, and physical health²⁰. These highly addictive and potent drugs pose risks to both users and the general public, including the possibility of mass poisonings and disease outbreaks.²¹ Adolescents are particularly susceptible due to misleading labels and online availability²², and drugs may become easier to produce with the development of technology.²³ Environmental problems that also induce health risks also occur during drug production.²⁴ The UK believes that through a multi-faceted approach including mandatory education starting from early childhood about the dangers of drugs with an emphasis on synthetic drugs, raising awareness through many ways such as social media, making technology to test for synthetic drugs widespread and easily accessible, regulating AI or certain chemicals used in drug production, enhancing online platform oversight, and providing healthcare or rehabilitation with the support of local NGOs will curb the rise of synthetic drugs.

Many efforts by the UK and the UN have been made to combat the rise of synthetic drugs. New Psychoactive Substances (NPSs) have been beginning to appear in the UK drug market as early as 2008, and the UK has had to come up with solutions for them. One of the biggest challenges was the sheer number of different types of drugs, which has increased exponentially, rising from 49 in 2011 to 101 in 2014. Many have been made illegal and others often contain illegal substances that are very powerful and often untested. The UK has seen the

¹⁶ "New, Dangerous Synthetic Opioid in D.C., Emerging in Tri-State Area." DEA, www.dea.gov/stories/2022/2022-06/2022-06-01/new-dangerous-synthetic-opioid-dc-emerging-tri-state-area. Accessed 25 Oct. 2023.

¹⁷ Urbina, F., Lentzos, F., Invernizzi, C. *et al.* Dual use of artificial-intelligence-powered drug discovery. *Nat Mach Intell* 4, 189–191 (2022). <https://doi.org/10.1038/s42256-022-00465-9>

¹⁸ Nichols, David. "Legal Highs: The Dark Side of Medicinal Chemistry." *Nature News*, Nature Publishing Group, 5 Jan. 2011, www.nature.com/articles/469007a.

¹⁹ "Synthetic Drugs (a.k.a. K2, Spice, Bath Salts, Etc.)." *National Archives and Records Administration*, National Archives and Records Administration, obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/ondcp/ondcp-fact-sheets/synthetic-drugs-k2-spice-bath-salts. Accessed 25 Oct. 2023.

²⁰ Creagh, S. *et al.* "The New Classes of Synthetic Illicit Drugs Can Significantly Harm the Brain: A Neuro Imaging Perspective With Full Review of MRI Findings." *Clinical Radiology & Imaging Journal*, U.S. National Library of Medicine, 2018, www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC6048967/.

²¹ Li P;Chen X;Xie PY;Chu P;Li DL;Li QQ;Shao YM;Jia ZW; "HIV Infection among New Synthetic Drug Abusers: A Pilot Study in Beijing." *Chinese Medical Journal*, U.S. National Library of Medicine, pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/23595387/. Accessed 25 Oct. 2023.

²² Great Valley Publishing Company, Inc. *Synthetic Drugs - Fake Substances, Real Dangers*, www.socialworktoday.com/archive/070212p12.shtml. Accessed 25 Oct. 2023.

²³ Weaver, Michael F. *et al.* "Designer Drugs 2015: Assessment and Management." *Addiction Science & Clinical Practice*, U.S. National Library of Medicine, 25 Mar. 2015, www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC4422150/.

²⁴ Bremond, Pierre. "The Impact of Drugs on the Environment." *Dianova*, 6 Sept. 2022, www.dianova.org/news/the-impact-of-drugs-on-the-environment/.

dangers of NPS when users were admitted to the hospital for overdose.²⁵ To combat this, the UK has proposed to blanket ban all NPS which could help raise awareness, as many “legal highs” are in fact, regulated.²⁶ PHE has also made NPS toolkits available for local authorities and contains information such as prevention and monitoring since effective local action is crucial in developing a general picture of unique local challenges.²⁷ National systems for gathering intelligence such as the Drugs Early Warning System and the National Intelligence Network, local sources such as local NDTMS data reports, as well as networks with clinicians, schools, and police departments also help drug-related knowledge available to anyone who needs such as information on treatment and symptoms. For example, Project NEPTUNE has made detailed information on NPS available to healthcare workers. Furthermore, the UK is aware that drug-related (especially NPS) harms to health often unfairly target those who are most vulnerable and has addressed this by also focusing on wider societal issues. Second, the United Nations has also taken a multi-faceted approach to stop synthetic drugs. For one, it has created a platform called the UN Toolkit on Synthetic Drugs which contains resources on challenges of drugs by providing practical and innovative tools. The UN also focuses on women and youth and emphasizes the importance of swift action.²⁸ The delegation of the UK expresses its appreciation for the United Nations’s actions and hopes to take part in resolving this global crisis.

The UK believes that through education on drug use, raising awareness about the dangers of synthetic drugs, regulating technology and certain chemicals, improving online drug sales oversight, improving technology for detecting synthetic drugs, and providing healthcare with the support of local NGOs to fight addiction and treat side effects of drug use will help in eradicating the rise of synthetic drugs. First, the UK believes it is much more cost-effective and practical to reduce demand rather than to combat supply or drug trafficking. Thus, education on the negative impacts of drug use with an emphasis on synthetic drugs and raising awareness about the dangers of synthetic drugs is crucial. Furthermore, to regulate drug production and trafficking, regulating certain common chemicals in synthetic drugs, especially medicinal chemistry, and the use of AI and improving technology to distinguish between synthetic drugs and other ones is important. To decrease the dangers of synthetic drugs during drug usage, making the technology widespread will combat death by drug overdose. To minimize drug trafficking by tackling an ever-growing online platform, oversight of online drug sales will be crucial. Lastly, treating those already affected by drugs through healthcare and rehabilitation and the use of techniques such as motivational interviewing and behavioral therapy will lead to solutions for numerous steps from production to consumption to effects. The UK believes that the rise of synthetic drugs is not a problem limited to certain countries, nor is it limited to certain regions. Therefore, the global society as a whole must contribute to addressing the rise of synthetic drugs.

²⁵ O’Connor, Rosanna. “The Challenge of Responding to New Synthetic Drugs.” *UK Health Security Agency*, 20 July 2015, ukhsa.blog.gov.uk/2015/07/20/the-challenge-of-responding-to-new-synthetic-drugs/.

²⁶ Office, Home. “Blanket Ban to Clamp down on ‘Legal Highs.’” *GOV.UK*, GOV.UK, 29 May 2015, www.gov.uk/government/news/blanket-ban-to-clamp-down-on-legal-highs.

²⁷ England, Public Health. “New Psychoactive Substances Toolkit for Commissioners.” *GOV.UK*, GOV.UK, 1 Nov. 2014, www.gov.uk/government/publications/new-psychoactive-substances-toolkit-for-commissioners.

²⁸ “UN Office on Drugs and Crime Launches Synthetic Drug Strategy to Prevent Global Crisis.” *United Nations : Information Service Vienna*, unis.unvienna.org/unis/en/pressrels/2021/unisnar1451.html. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

Topic 4: Addressing the Dangers of Corporate Data Collection

The delegation of the United Kingdom is fully aware of the dangers of corporate data collection. With the rise of the internet and especially social media, corporations can get access to vast amounts of information. However, this raises privacy concerns and risks of identity theft. The data collected often contains sensitive information, which can be potentially breached or sold to data brokers or third parties for revenue to be used for financial gain, or to influence large populations of people, sometimes even for unethical purposes.²⁹ Even with well-intended legislation requiring the company to provide data to customers if requested such as the CCPA (California Consumer Privacy Act)³⁰ and the EU General Data Protection Regulation (GDPA)³¹, It is often full of obscure spreadsheets and legal jargon. Furthermore, it is not universal; only some countries have such laws, and because it is incredibly time-consuming³², many do not request the data. Despite this, many policies assume that consumers read them and make informed choices., Moreover, many are dubious whether the data is even accurate enough to be used for influencing the corporations' decisions, since a significant portion of the data are estimates based on choices, using this information to make assumptions about society as a whole may become problematic. The UK believes that mandating encrypted formats for sensitive information and mandating companies to ask customers about their data, as well as providing consumers with easy-to-read reports about their data will encourage both businesses to ethically use their data and consumers to take an interest in their data. Lastly, requiring corporations to report data breaches to authorities within a set time frame will ensure it becomes easier to track down the breach. The UK firmly believes it should be the responsibility of corporations to use their data ethically without harming consumers.

The United Kingdom and the UN have taken measures to address the dangers of corporate data collection and help those affected by it. First, the UK is aware of the values of personal data and the consumer benefits but is also aware of risks, as algorithms can deduce someone's background with the use of AI, and this information could be used unethically.³³ Thus, it has passed the Data Protection Act 2018, which established the framework for data protection in the UK, and the UK General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), which specified key principles and rights/obligations³⁴. Second, the UN has also taken measures to address the dangers of corporate data collection, which can be a powerful tool, but also can be used to manipulate consumers' behavior. For example, OHCHR has organized experts to consult on the matter and has published reports to further explore the challenges data collection brings to human rights such as the right to privacy as the General Assembly and the Human Rights Council had requested. It has also established the UN Guiding Principles on Business and

²⁹ Sathe, Gopal. "How Sai Baba Was Made to Spy on Your Phone for Credit Ratings." *HuffPost*, HuffPost, 8 July 2019, www.huffpost.com/archive/in/entry/fintech-apps-privacy-snooping-credit-vidya_in_5d1cbe34e4b082e55373370a.

³⁰ "California Consumer Privacy Act (CCPA)." *State of California - Department of Justice - Office of the Attorney General*, 10 May 2023, oag.ca.gov/privacy/ccpa.

³¹ 5. "European Union - Data Privacy and Protection." *International Trade Administration | Trade.Gov*, www.trade.gov/european-union-data-privacy-and-protection#:~:text=GDPR%20is%20a%20comprehensive%20privacy,for%20the%20movement%20of%20data. Accessed 27 Oct. 2023.

³² McDonald, Aleccia M, and Lorrie Faith Cranor. *The Cost of Reading Privacy Policies*, lorrie.cranor.org/pubs/readingPolicyCost-authorDraft.pdf. Accessed 27 Oct. 2023.

³³ *Human Rights (Joint Committee) - Committees - UK Parliament*, committees.parliament.uk/committee/93/human-rights-joint-committee. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

³⁴ "UK Business Data Survey 2021: Detailed Findings." *GOV.UK*, www.gov.uk/government/statistics/uk-business-data-survey-2021/uk-business-data-survey-2021-detailed-findings#how-businesses-use-data. Accessed 1 Nov. 2023.

Human Rights and Human Rights 9, helping both governments and companies to help them follow a set guideline. It has also worked to increase public awareness about this issue. ,

The UK believes that mandating the encryption of personal data and requiring companies to report data breaches to authorities in a set time frame, requiring corporations to ask about the use of personal information, and providing consumers with their data in an accessible way, will lower the risk of harming consumers and encourage ethical use of personal data. First, the UK recognizes that it is the corporations' responsibility to use consumers' data ethically. Thus, to protect the data and to act against any possible breaches, the UK suggests mandating the encryption of personal data and requiring reports about breaches in about 72 hours for authorities to be able to track the breaches more effectively, with the CCPA and GDPR as precedents. Second, corporations should have a responsibility to consumers to ask about the personal data they are using, including information on how it is used, why it is being collected, and where it is being stored, and the data should be presented in a way that all people who request for data can read. The UK believes that it is crucial to pique the interest of consumers and influence corporations to use data ethically, and this can be achieved through legislative measures.